Chapter Sixty-Five

Mansa Musa of Mali

Between 1312 and 1360, the riches of Mali become known to the outside world

In 1312, the king of Mali handed the throne over to his first cousin (once removed) for safekeeping, and set off on an adventure.

His name was Abubakari II; he was the nephew of Sundiata, his mother's brother, the great Muslim conqueror who had founded Mali as an independent kingdom. Mali was now half a century old. It had swallowed the nearby cities of Gao and Mani on the east; the entire Senegal river valley was enfolded; Mali stretched all the way to the West Africa coast.

Beyond this lay the ocean.

"The king who was my predecessor," his first cousin later explained, "did not believe that it was impossible to discover the furthest limit of the Atlantic Ocean and wished vehemently to do so. So he equipped 200 ships filled with men and the same number equipped with gold, water, and provisions enough to last them for years." Abubakari gave strict orders to his newly appointed admiral: Sail west, and do not return until you have come to the end of your food and drink.

Long after, a single ship returned. Its captain reported to the king that the entire fleet had been caught in a strong current, with only his craft left behind: "They did not return," he told Abubakari, "and no more was seen of them and we do not know what became of them." The Mali expedition had been caught, apparently, in the North Equatorial Current: the Drifts of the Trade Winds, the